

Reduced Relative Clauses

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Shorten a relative clause by dropping the pronoun and using a participle.

Now that you're comfortable with who/which/that, let's make your writing tighter and more natural by dropping the relative pronoun when possible.

Rules

a) Active clauses → -ing form

When the relative pronoun is the subject of an active verb, drop "who/which/that" + the verb, and use the -ing form instead.

- The man who is standing there is my uncle. → The man standing there is my uncle.
- People who live in cities often complain about noise. → People living in cities often complain about noise.

b) Passive clauses → past participle

- The book which was written by Tolkien is a classic. → The book written by Tolkien is a classic.
- The car that was damaged in the accident has been repaired. → The car damaged in the accident has been repaired.

c) When you can't reduce

You can't reduce when the relative pronoun is the object, not the subject: "The book that I read" cannot become "The book reading" — there's no subject relationship to reduce.

Examples

- The man standing there is my uncle.
- People living in cities often complain about noise.
- The book written by Tolkien is a classic.
- The car damaged in the accident has been repaired.
- The woman sitting next to me is a doctor.
- Documents signed before the deadline will be accepted.

Common Mistakes

× The man standed there is my uncle.

✓ The man standing there is my uncle.

Active reduced clauses use the -ing form, not the past tense.

× The book writing by Tolkien is a classic.

✓ The book written by Tolkien is a classic.

Passive reduced clauses use the past participle (written), not the -ing form.

× The book reading is on the table. (meaning: the book that I am reading)

✓ The book that I am reading is on the table.

You can't reduce a clause where the pronoun is the object — there's no active/passive subject relationship here.

Summary

- Active relative clause → drop the pronoun + verb, use -ing.
- Passive relative clause → drop the pronoun + "was/were", use the past participle.
- You can only reduce when the relative pronoun is the subject of its clause.

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